

An Analysis of the Historical Origins, Core Practices, and Diversity of Islam

A. Historical Origins and the Five Pillars of Islam (15 Points)

Historical Origins

The historical foundations of Islam are rooted in the Arabian Peninsula during the 7th century CE, a region marked by long-distance trade routes and a complex mix of pre-Islamic natural religions, gods, and demons. The faith was revealed to the Prophet Muhammad (born in Mecca), who worked initially as a herdsman and later gained experience as a merchant on long trading trips. The defining moment occurred in 610 CE, when Muhammad, at the age of 40, received his first revelation from the Angel Gabriel. This teaching of absolute monotheism—that "There is no God but God"—challenged the existing political and religious order of Mecca, which relied on the polytheistic worship centered around the **Kaaba**. Due to this challenge, Muhammad and his followers were banished from Mecca. They found refuge in present-day Medina, an event known as the **Hijra**. Here, Muhammad evolved into the political and military leader of a fast-growing Islamic community. His successes culminated in his triumphant march back to Mecca in 630 CE, where he removed all idols from the Kaaba. Muhammad died in 632 CE at the age of 63. Shortly after his death, a foundational dispute over his successor split the community into the two major branches: **Sunnis** and **Shiites**. The divine revelations that form the Quran were conveyed to him over a period of **23 years**.

The Five Pillars of Islam

The **Five Pillars** are the framework for a Muslim's life, constituting the five obligatory acts of worship for all Muslims:

1. **The Creed (Shahada):** The profession of faith: "There is no God but God and Muhammad is his prophet." **Importance:** This is the foundational declaration of **Tawhid** (absolute monotheism) and the essential requirement for conversion.
2. **Daily Prayers (Salat):** Performing ritual prayer five times a day, facing the sacred Kaaba. **Importance:** It establishes a regular connection with God; the act of prostration (**Sujud**) is described as the moment closest to God, offering spiritual rest.
3. **Fasting (Sawm):** The obligatory fast observed during the daylight hours of the month of Ramadan. **Importance:** It is an act of spiritual discipline, self-purification, and empathy for the poor.
4. **Alms-Giving (Zakat):** The obligatory giving of a fixed portion of one's wealth to charity and those in need. **Importance:** It purifies one's wealth and soul, promoting economic justice within the community.
5. **The Pilgrimage (Hajj):** The great pilgrimage to Mecca, which all able-bodied Muslims are obliged to undertake at least once. **Importance:** It is the most important journey in a Muslim's life,

promoting a powerful sense of universal unity.

B. International Diversity within Islam (15 Points)

Islam, despite its common core rooted in the Quran and the **Sunnah**, exhibits immense international diversity, where the religious core is often "overlaid with cultural rules and norms." The global Muslim population, with the majority now residing in Southeast Asia (200 million in Indonesia alone), demonstrates the faith's wide breadth and assimilation into various cultures.

Specific Examples of Diversity from the Film

1. Cultural Assimilation and Pre-Islamic Rituals in Indonesia

In **Cirebon, West Java, Indonesia**, the celebration of **Mawlid al-Nabi** (the Prophet's birthday) highlights the unique blend of Islam and local culture. The practice incorporates **pre-Islamic birth rituals** and customs, such as offering fragrant flowers and blossoms, and people fetching water from the royal palace well, which is revered as a source of life. This practice **departs** from strict, fundamentalist interpretations (like **Wahhabism** in Saudi Arabia), as the documentary notes that some Muslims view this use of symbolic rituals and cultural reverence as **idolatry** because only God may be the object of religious worship.

2. Interpretive Diversity and Gender Roles in Education

The contrast in educational institutions (*pesantren*) illustrates interpretive diversity. The **Al-Mizan School** in West Java actively promotes a line **against extremism and fundamentalist interpretations**. Its focus is on teaching that Islam is a "power to create a peace" and promotes **tolerance** and **peaceful coexistence**. Crucially, **girls are particularly promoted** in their education. This model **departs** from the strict gender segregation and literalist approach enforced by fundamentalists (such as the Indonesian branch of Hizb ut-Tahrir), representing a **liberal Islamic** approach that is viewed critically by those who demand rigid, gender-segregated religious observance.

Critical Analysis and Conclusion (10 Points)

The central tension defining modern Islam is the **critical dichotomy between its mandated global unity and its inherent interpretive fluidity**. While the **Five Pillars** and the **Hajj** successfully function as unifying rituals—creating a singular, global identity regardless of sect or origin—the meaning and application of the Quran and Sunnah remain subject to profound geopolitical and cultural divergence. This interpretive fluidity leads to both constructive assimilation (e.g., the tolerance and cultural blend in Indonesian educational models) and destructive fundamentalism (e.g., the misinterpretation of **Jihad** as solely a call to violence). The challenge is not merely managing these differences but recognizing that the failure to facilitate effective **intra-community dialogue** allows political conflicts and literalistic readings to fragment the unified religious core. Therefore, the future strength of the global Muslim community relies on its ability to embrace the peaceful, adaptable tradition exemplified by its diverse local cultures while resisting the divisive, singular narratives of extremism.

Key Vocabulary and Important Terms (5 Points)

Term	Definition and Significance
Prophet Muhammad	The final messenger of God, who received the divine revelations (Quran) over 23 years.
Kaaba	The cube-shaped building in Mecca; the most sacred site and the direction of prayer.
Hijra	The migration of Muhammad from Mecca to Medina (622 CE), marking the start of the Islamic calendar.
Sunnis	The largest branch of Islam, who follow the <i>Sunnah</i> (Prophet's example).
Shiites	The smaller branch of Islam, who believe the successor to Muhammad must be a direct relative.
Tawhid	The concept of absolute monotheism (the oneness and uniqueness of God).
Shahada	The Creed ("There is no God but God and Muhammad is his prophet."); the first Pillar.
Salat, Sawm, Zakat, Hajj	The remaining four obligatory Pillars (Prayer, Fasting, Alms-Giving, Pilgrimage).
Wahhabism	A particularly narrow and strict Sunni interpretation of Islam, dominant in Saudi Arabia.
Jihad	An Arabic word meaning "struggle" or "striving." Interpreted as both internal, spiritual striving and external, defensive struggle.